

Giants in the Fields: Agribusiness and Farm Labor Politics in the United States

Peter Benson, Washington University in St. Louis

Abstract

This article examines the cultural politics of farm labor organizing in North Carolina's tobacco-producing region. Exploring the form and content of a theatrical performance staged in a labor camp by union affiliates, I show how the play builds on strategic cultural stereotypes about growers and workers. The play focuses on the theme of farmworker squalor and questions of who is responsible and who is to blame. While the play clearly has immediate pedagogical and political value for workers and participants, a narrative of good actors and bad actors occludes a full appreciation of the role of multinational capital and government neglect in inducing harm endured by farm labor and constraints faced by growers. This case study permits insights into the relevance of cultural performance in contemporary efforts to invoke ethical concerns and make policy improvements in agriculture and to develop constructive criticism about farm labor organizing and outreach strategies.

Keywords: farm labor, unions, agribusiness, tobacco, theater, North Carolina

Opening Scene

Juan and Dolores are played by Student Action with Farmworkers (SAF) summer interns, a young white man and a young white woman. They stand at the center of the makeshift stage, a clearing in the grassy common area beside the barracks that house mostly Mexican farmworkers. "Our prayers have been answered!" Dolores announces in Spanish. "The day that we have all been struggling for together is finally here! Now we can celebrate! It's taken us five long years, but we have achieved an important victory for farmworkers." Dolores refers to the successful end of a boycott against a major produce company orchestrated by labor organizers in North Carolina.

"From now on," Juan says, "growers [*rancheros*] will have to abide by this important contract, which will protect our rights and improve working conditions. If one of us gets injured, the grower must pay attention. And we will receive a wage increase!"

Although the SAF summer internship program does not involve the intensive relationship building that ethnography does, lasting a summer and putting interns into directed and organized forms of interac-

tion, it is qualitatively different than the tourism that often characterizes extracurricular activities of college students who seek intercultural experience. Based on 20 months of field study with tobacco growers and workers in eastern North Carolina conducted since 2003, this article examines the cultural politics of solidarity embedded in the performance of the play by SAF interns. This case study is a springboard for a broader analysis of labor advocacy struggles and strategies in the context of cultural diversity and a rigid racial hierarchy.

SAF is a nonprofit organization that has been an important protagonist in struggles for social justice and farm labor rights for decades (Smith-Nonini 2005; SAF 2008). Prominent chapters at universities across the country partner with labor unions and community health centers to facilitate programs through which students can interface with the agricultural worker population, mainly undocumented migrants from Mexico and Central America. Interns are placed in these organizations and work there for the summer, immersed in practical aspects of the advocacy work that connects vulnerable workers to the social service sector and the broader domain of farm labor politics. In the case of the play, this group of interns was assigned to assist the Farm Labor Organizing Committee (FLOC), a national labor union that has successfully boycotted major agribusiness corporations.¹

Word of the interns' arrival spread quickly throughout the camp, where two dozen workers (a medium-sized camp, the region's bigger operations having upwards of a hundred workers) were doing the usual: resting under a shady tree, watching television, washing clothes, playing soccer, fixing an old pickup truck, consuming alcohol, and other activities to engage time. Most workers lack personal transportation and are confined to space owned by their employer, even when off the clock. Adding to an experience of constant dispossession and confinement, labor camps are intensely boring places, hot and uncomfortable during summer days (Benson 2008a). Some workers rolled their eyes when the interns arrived. Migrants commonly describe the work of labor organizers and their affiliates as sometimes annoying, "*una molestia*." They are tired after work and on weekends when organizers visit to give an earful, ask about workplace or housing problems

with an eye toward filing a legal complaint against the grower, and recruit union members. Migrants have been reluctant to join the union or raise concerns about the facilities and the work for several reasons described later. Realizing this, the interns quickly warmed the mood by announcing that the purpose of this particular visit was not “la política,” politicking about labor and rights, but rather “una diversión.”

The workers with whom I sit on the grassy clearing smirk at each other and at me. Perhaps they relay sentiment about the awkward physical attractiveness of some of the female interns who are dressed as male farmworkers. Perhaps there is a mix of contentment and embarrassment in having one’s livelihood portrayed and valorized by young people who will most likely never work in manual labor. If nothing else, the workers enjoy this play in spite of the reservations about union organizing common among them, while the interns enjoy the direct interaction with a vulnerable population with which they feel great solidarity. They later told me that they sincerely feel like they are making a difference to improve the lives of farmworkers through this internship program. Eager to do a good job and not miss their rehearsed lines, the young actors who play the labor organizers and workers laugh at their fumbled Spanish and incomplete accents just as the workers do. The camp is alive with a kind of energy that is usually dampened in weekend chores and boredom. Social justice is thematized. The toils of stoop labor and camp life are indicted in a play that takes clear aim at the pervasive tendency in the United States to regard migrant farmworkers as a faceless and abstract group and the conditions of structural violence (Farmer 2004) that affect them, including deplorable wages and poverty, forms of stigma and racism, occupational health and safety hazards, poor health and limited access to services, and the constant threat of deportation (Griffith and Kissam 1994; Smith-Nonini 1999; Thompson and Wiggins 2002; Villarejo 2003; Oxfam America 2004; Arcury and Quandt 2007). Boundaries are blurred in the liminality that is a common defining feature of dramaturgy. These are college students at elite universities, most of them white, a couple of them from farmworker and immigrant backgrounds, who here embody the role and speak in the voice of labor.

The play, entitled *Giants in the Fields*, was written by other SAF interns in a preceding summer. They put a great deal of time into developing it so that it reflects a concrete understanding of migrant life and work, teaching the students while also connecting with audiences of workers. Interns associated with FLOC now use the same script and broadly perform the play throughout tobacco regions over and over again. The play, largely about having fun and providing a good

laugh for everyone on hand, is also about serious issues. It replaces the stereotype of a faceless machine with positive images of workers and negative images of the mainstream culture. These representations embed political critique in the play, but, as we will see, may also entail some unintended consequences that depreciate the fullest possible training of students and possibilities for labor union organizing and outreach.

Dolores finishes her speech. “Now, my friends, we have the difficult task of teaching all workers, especially the new ones, about their rights. We will continue to recruit new union members. We at the labor union know you struggle and barely make ends meet. We know you work long hours in the hot sun away from your families and loved ones. We know you work with dangerous pesticides, living in cramped substandard housing. We want to continue to improve conditions for all workers, because we are in solidarity with you.”



Figure 1. H2A guest workers harvesting tobacco leaf in North Carolina, August 2005. Photograph taken by author.

Setting the Stage: Growers, Migrants, and Agribusiness

The version of the play that I witnessed and took notes on transpired in the summer of 2005 in a labor camp located in Wilson County, the hub of my field study. This article represents part of a larger study of the many aspects of tobacco agriculture and Mexican farm labor migration in North Carolina. My goal has been to understand what everyday social life is like at

tobacco farm workplaces and in tobacco households and labor camps given several broader processes, including the national context of antitobacco politics, the globalization and industrialization of food and farm chains and transformations in agrarian life, and the intense political and cultural struggles over immigration. Apart from conducting roughly 200 ethnographic interviews with growers, workers, and labor advocates in the country's most active tobacco-producing region, located about 1 hour east of Raleigh, I worked on a few farms, did all of the manual labor workers do, and frequented labor camps almost every weekend.

Ethnographic research in the agrarian settings affected by agribusiness integration and transnational migration is helpful for understanding the many social dynamics that are part of rural class formation and the division of agricultural labor. Anthropologists of agriculture have noted the fundamental point that growers and workers have more in common than they think in an era of vertical integration and tremendous corporate power (Rouse 1991; Edid 1994; Durrenberger and Erem 2005). But the potential for solidaristic thinking and behavior is often fragmented by divisive cultural themes and issues. Tobacco growers often regard the workforce as a fundamentally different class of people and locally advance processes of stigmatization and segregation that widely affect racialized populations in the United States. Along with other anthropologists of tobacco agriculture I have emphasized that these power dynamics are not inevitable. They reflect a history of labor subordination in the agricultural sector as well as recent structural changes in the tobacco economy and the tendency among growers to respond in defensive ways (Kingsolver 2007; Benson 2008a, 2008b).

In the pre-1950s U.S. South, an insular regional labor market confined African Americans to manual agricultural labor, tenancy, and low wages, conditions rooted in plantation slavery (Daniel 1972). There was also a less visible system of seasonal and geographically mobile labor. As early as the 1890s, black and European immigrant workers followed the harvest from truck farms in the Northeast to produce operations in Florida (Hahamovitch 1997). As with the tenancy system, this mobile workforce was built on well-organized strategies of social control, including vagrancy laws, forced labor, and physical brutality. Migrant crews were often segregated into dilapidated labor camps, company towns, and ghettoized enclaves placed outside city limits (Rothenberg 1998:33–34).

A tradition of legal exceptionalism has historically regarded farm labor as distinct from other kinds of work, excluding farmworkers from the rights and

protections guaranteed workers in other industries (Rothenberg 1998:36; Schell 2002). These exceptions disproportionately denied minority groups, the bulk of farm laborers, aspects of citizenship afforded white workers in other sectors (Lipsitz 1995:372). The federal government has generally backed the social power and economic interests of growers. In the wartime labor shortage of the 1940s, Florida sugar growers maintained depressed wages and a controllable workforce by importing foreign-born workers from the Caribbean through a formal government “guest worker” program. The trend to rescale the labor pool to an international level to maintain a supply of unskilled labor willing to work for minimum wages and live in squalid conditions would drive dramatic changes in the country's farm labor workforce for the rest of the century (Hollander 2006).

Farm mechanization and market globalization intensified the postwar need for flexible and inexpensive labor arrangements (Winters 1998). The crew leader system, rooted in the 1950s when Mexican American farmworkers migrated to Florida and established themselves as labor contractors, filled this niche. The regional workforce has since undergone a “steady process of Latinization” (Rothenberg 1998:44). Rural dislocation and poverty in Mexico, exacerbated by international economic liberalization (e.g., the North American Free Trade Agreement) have driven northward migration (Massey et al. 1987; Kingsolver 2001; Delgado-Wise and Covarrubias 2006). North Carolina's Hispanic population increased 10-fold since 1970, which is triple the national rate (Kasarda and Johnson 2006).

Although important farm labor reforms came out of the cultural and political struggles of the civil rights era, it was not until 1983 that federal standards for labor camps were established. Even then implementation was slow (Griffith and Kissam 1994:17–21). In 1990 North Carolina established uniform inspection standards, ending a longstanding rule that excluded growers housing fewer than 12 workers from regulation (*Wilson Daily Times* 1989). While state law now stipulates specific standards for the housing structure (North Carolina Department of Labor 2008), government neglect and noncompliance in the private sector are the norm (Smith-Nonini 1999). Owned by the grower and provided free as part of the employment relationship, labor camps are the facilities where migrant farmworkers reside during the harvest season. Many other people frequent the camps: labor contractors, sex workers, health outreach workers, drug vendors, labor organizers, and friends and familiars of the workers. Growers are most often absent from their camps, which are commonly nestled in woodlands or fields near the farms. Potential legal and compliance issues remain distant from the grow-

er and the public. Labor camps come in all shapes and sizes, but they are almost always overcrowded and rundown. "Farmworkers are among the worst-housed groups in the United States," writes one observer (Holden 2002:169; Early et al. 2006; Gentry et al. 2007).

The labor camp where the play took place was in good shape compared with truly squalid conditions found elsewhere. Although camp conditions tend to be better on small farms, where there may be less crowding and closer relationships with the grower, this camp is owned by a relatively large tobacco grower. To help ensure cleanliness, he is a regular presence in the camp and learned Spanish to facilitate communication. The facilities are functional, bedrooms not crowded, the kitchen ample if basic, and the grounds clean. Perhaps the main reason this camp is cleaner and roomier than most is that the grower participates in the federal H2A program, legally hiring nonpermanent guest workers. He is proud to comply with the law and complains that growers who do not comply benefit from an unfair economic advantage. As part of the program, he pays a fixed wage that is higher than the minimum wage. The program also mandates fees for transporting workers to and from their hometowns in Mexico each season, creating an international cycle whereby most of the crew returns each year to work for the same grower. This is a key difference between the H2A program and the informal labor market, where undocumented workers tend to remain in the United States for a lengthier period of time. They often have to work to repay debts incurred to finance their passage; with intensified violence and policing along the border, many choose to remain in the United States because of the costs and difficulties related to a return trip. Claiming that the federal program is too expensive, the vast majority of growers use the informal labor market. Another stated reason for aversion to the H2A program has, in fact, been the increasing legal and political power of FLOC within the guest worker program. There is also the larger hegemony of antiunion sentiment in the South, and many growers simply refuse to hire unionized workers. That domestic tobacco prices have declined dramatically in the wake of recent deregulation measures compounds this exploitative and illegal activity. Growers who bypass the formal program do not usually face the legal and political scrutiny that formal participation might entail. It is also more difficult for government officials and union organizers to access labor camps and workplaces that are not part of the formal system. During the 1990s guest worker hiring expanded from <200 to about 10,000 employees in North Carolina, making it the country's largest user of guest workers (Oxfam America 2004:19). Since that time, with declining prices and rising production costs for agricultural commodi-

ties and with expanded union organizing activity, the formal workforce has dwindled to a sliver of the state's hundreds of thousands of agricultural workers (Smith-Nonini 2005; Griffith 2007).

The "paranoid" political style that the anthropologist Kathryn Dudley (2000) identifies as common among U.S. farmers is manifest differently across regions, with particular combinations of global and local factors that contribute to feelings of threat. By virtue of involvement in a problematized commodity chain, tobacco growers are forced to wrestle with society's changing attitudes about tobacco in ways that are often deeply personal and difficult (Griffith 2009a). An unintended effect of public efforts to control tobacco use and the antitobacco movement, which has intentionally demonized tobacco companies, has been the growth of a defensive posture among growers (Benson 2010). "It's not fair how tobacco farmers are portrayed in the media. We are not understood," a tobacco grower tells me in an interview. "It all starts with the word *tobacco*. There are negative connotations from the start." But there is no evidence of a concerted attack on tobacco livelihoods waged by public health groups. It is a bit like the idea that Christianity is under attack in the United States, which rouses political and social defensiveness among adherents. Fantastical scandals of ex-privilege, where victimhood is claimed by relatively advantaged constituencies who now seem negatively marked by some difference or problem, incite sometimes dangerous responses and policy perspectives (Berlant 1997). Local media accounts and tobacco growers tend to blame the public health tobacco-control movement for conditions of economic hardship and uncertainty. In fact, these conditions are the direct result of a market shift driven by the multinational tobacco industry's investment in offshore production capacities since the 1970s and its decision to maximize profits by purchasing more foreign leaf. As in other industries, tobacco companies benefit from lax environmental and labor laws in many countries (National Institute for Tobacco-Free Kids 1999).

The New Deal program that long sheltered U.S. tobacco growers from market fluctuations was dismantled in 2004 to reduce leaf prices and increase the competitive advantage of domestic leaf on the world market. Tobacco companies pushed for this policy change by aggressively purchasing leaf in the developing world, mainly in South America and Africa. Built on neoliberal, free-trade ideals, the change authorized by Congress was intended to reinvigorate the declining industry. In fact, it has created a whole new set of uncertainties and challenges. The traditional auction system was terminated. There is a new system of private, 1-year contracts between farmers

and multinational tobacco firms. These temporary contracts are now the only way to market tobacco. Prices are tightly ratcheted to efficient and fully mechanized methods; this unevenly benefits larger farms, and there has been a massive exodus from tobacco farming and increased rural unemployment. Contracting demands intensive capital investment on the part of farmers, making them more dependent on tobacco livelihoods and companies, as seen in vertical integration in poultry and hogs (Durrenberger and Thu 1996). It has helped to push small farms where labor conditions and relations are likely to be of a higher quality out of business, thereby contributing to the race to the bottom in farm wages and working and living conditions.

Contracting also contributes to local social conditions in which dynamics of stigmatization, segregation, class differentiation, and racialization thrive and cluster. Tobacco growers have a lot at stake in their tobacco bales – livelihood, hundreds of thousands of dollars in capital investments, and the pride and public moral status associated with being a successful farmer – all of which hinge on keeping a contract. It is important to remember that these are not just farmers; they are *tobacco* farmers (Griffith 2009a). The public morality filters down so that a combination of symbolic, material, and existential predicaments induce grower responses that often take the form of antagonism towards workers, union organizers, the public health, and the government in general, all of which are blamed for structural problems and threats of farm loss. Maintaining boundaries of essential difference between themselves and the farm labor workforce is one way to come to grips with economic instability and their own experiences of being blamed, diminished, and threatened (Benson 2008b:370). Growers do not furnish labor camps that they themselves would inhabit because, regrettably, they often see migrants as deserving less and because pressures of international competition and corporate power are a trickle-down economics sanctioned by government neglect that keeps wages low and motivates against improvements in the farm labor infrastructure. Noncompliance for growers is a beneficial and strategic way to compete in international commodity markets, maintain a company contract under the duress of stringent demands, while consumers, who may know very little about how agricultural products are harvested, reap the benefits of cheaply priced products. To locate growers and workers as part of a shared predicament is not to neglect the division of labor that clearly exists on farms or let growers off the hook for noncompliance and a worldview that can condone segregation. Cultural issues are galvanized amidst international agricultural restructuring, which makes growers a vector of harm, people who cannot

afford to improve their labor camps and are emboldened, amidst their own feelings of threat and jeopardy, to blame workers for squalid conditions and illegality.

Dialectics of Bubba

After the opening scene, the play shifts location, now set at the bus station in North Carolina where guest workers arrive from Mexico and are then transported to individual farms. The state's growers who use the H2A program contract with a private corporation that furnishes the transportation and administrative services, owns this terminal (with walls that are colorfully, if also condescendingly painted with desert motifs), and directly engages with the labor union to handle legal compliance issues on behalf of growers. This last aspect of the program is what Dolores was referring to in the opening scene, the contract that FLOC now has with this private labor recruitment and contract management firm.

Opposite the group of interns who are playing the role of the guest workers is Bubba, who is played by a female actor wearing coveralls and a ball cap, standing before a red, white, and blue banner that says "Bienvenidos to America." Bubba makes a loud speech in an affected gringo accent, the female actor speaking in a sarcastic tone, which is deep, guttural, and pretentious and gets the audience chuckling. The speech, all in English, is translated into Spanish by another intern playing the role of the interpreter. "Men, we are glad you are here to work on the best farmland in the world and for the best growers this side of the Mississippi. Now, you may have heard fairy tales or nightmares about this place. The work is hard. But we are your friends," Bubba now switches idioms, stating creepily, "sus amigos."

A feminized and blustery Bubba continues mouthing words silently as Carlos comes to center stage, turns to the audience, opens his suitcase to display various belts, and gives a proud speech in Spanish.

I am Carlos, otherwise known as the belt man. I am from a long line of leather workers. They are like snakes to me. I am the charmer. I wrap them around my hand and begin working their skins: patterns of raindrops, naked women, a bull, or a goat, whatever you wish. I can work your hats and jackets, but a belt is an endless straight line of possibilities. I use fine ivory string and special oils to shine your leather brighter. By day I work the fields, but at night I run the business of carving your dreams.

Here the play singles out the migrant as an individual with vocations, passions, and skills that are much different than stoop labor. "The work is not

dignified and nothing will change in our society until the people who do farm work are treated with respect," one of the interns told me in an informal conversation after the performance. The play is intended to intervene not just at the level of cultural stereotypes, but also at the level of moral imagination, framing migrant labor as a problem deserving outrage and contempt. Of course, in this case, with the audience comprised of workers themselves, the play is preaching to the choir. The play aims to let the workers know that the interns (and the labor union) are keenly aware of the harsh living conditions and the cultural ideologies that mystify them. This story of structural violence is relayed not in a documentary fashion but through personal stories with which workers can presumably identify. Again, given that this is an internship, the fundamental aim is to create a context through which different groups of people can connect in a way that is fun rather than boring, so that what is a diversion for the workers is a potential learning and transformative experience for the students. Carlos steps back in line (Bubba still mouthing his speech) and Juan moves to center stage.

Hello compadres, brothers. It is here [North Carolina, the United States] where I put my brown hands to the soil working for these gringos to keep food on my family's table. I am really a poet. I round out the sounds of Mexico, the bosom of the mountains, the cries of the children and mothers with my words. I am just a messenger trying to speak of the weight that a brown man must carry to make it [*sobrevivir*] in this world.

The play presents farm labor as what it is: something done out of necessity. In passions unbeknownst to aloof gringos who import labor, pay wages, and profit from proletarianization there are contributions that have no price tag and find no existing market. The involvement of students in this performance helps them to develop critical thinking skills with regard to the way that livelihoods are structured not in accordance with capabilities or desires but rather under the sway of international trade structures that involve uneven access to life chances. The play encourages the participants to question "the total correspondence between acts and identities" that is often the basis for evaluations of citizenship and moral worth in the United States (Berlant 1997:17). What one does (or where one comes from or has been) is commonly reckoned to be an essential marker of who one is, which "makes people public and generic," the literary critic Lauren Berlant writes, makes "them into *kinds* of people" (1997:1). At the same time as the play will appeal to a dominant depiction of Mexican identity in which culture, language, and nationalism overlap (which may be intended to help the

interns understand Mexico and Mexicans in positive terms and pique an interest in the country's literature and other cultural productions) it announces that what workers do is not definitive of who they are as human beings, that they ought to be regarded as individuals and not as members of an essentialized nation, and that farm labor threatens their ability to contribute to society in the fullest way.

"I write about my wife and family to keep them in my heart and close to me," Juan continues. "I am inspired by such heroes as Zapata, Pablo Neruda, and Guillermo Prieto. They write of such beautiful and powerful things for our countries." He removes a notepad from his back pocket and steps upstage with the other men ("continuing not to listen to Bubba," the script states). Another man now moves to the center and begins.

Some call me Guadalupe, but my real name is Miguel. I am a dancer by trade – the salsa, cumbia. Yes I know how to dance all your pains away. I am here to make extra money for my dream of a dance studio in Mexico one day. Here in North Carolina, between work [when not working] I teach dance lessons to the men, teach them how to move their lady friends across the dance floor like water. You too can sign up if you like. Here in the fields can be backbreaking work as you know. But dancing and music can make the heart remember your lover and children and the sunsets of our Mexico.

The play may appeal to the audience of workers because it depicts the commonest difficulties of labor migration and communicates the message that the students and their mentors get it. The play talks about the pains of living away from home and family, existing in the shadows of the society, and often being seen as nothing more than a workhorse. Several aspects of the characters seem scripted to fit the actual experiences of migrants: the machismo flare and tacit heterosexuality of the dance instructor capable of accessing women seems framed to appeal to the young men in the audience, many of whom will catch a ride with a friend on Saturday nights to party at one of the various dance halls in the surrounding counties; the hope of translating farm wages into capital for entrepreneurial ventures back home (Portes 2007); and the ubiquitous assumption of pseudonyms by migrants as a protective measure, a means of identification, or a statement about their skin color, hair style, personality, or hometown. There is also Miguel's reference to time "between work," making it clear that the authors of the play are aware that migrant life has as much to do with what happens in the labor camp as the fields. All of this serves the multiple functions of creating a learning environment for the interns that involves

field study, putting on a show for the workers to boost their morale and indicate that labor union affiliates understand their realities, and fomenting feelings of pride and critical thinking among both the interns and the workers. The play is not entirely true to life. It does not go into the health disparities and health risks that are related to high levels of alcohol and drug consumption, sex work, and criminal activity in labor camps (Arcury and Quandt 2007). But part of its capacity to establish solidarity involves touching on aspects of reality to lend credence to the script and position the interns as unlike the typical gringo.

As the actors parody Bubba and take on the role of migrants they come to seem and perhaps feel distant from the mainstream culture where opposition and hostility to immigration are common and seem linked to potent levels of ignorance in the society. Meanwhile, the juxtaposition of Bubba and the migrants and the reference to literatures and intellectual movements of Latin America allows the play to challenge the common cultural assumption that underwrites the division of agricultural labor: white managers are thought to possess the skill and knowledge necessary for business and manual laborers are said to be unskilled. It is ethnographically important that migrant workers commonly brag about having knowledge of agriculture that rivals that of the bosses, talking at length about their experiences on farms back home and in the United States and the basic fact that without their skill – knowing which tobacco plants will not survive and need to be tossed aside in the process of transplanting, for example, or knowing how to exact unwanted suckers from the mature plants – the growers would ironically not be capable of achieving profits or posturing as independent business owners.

After the handful of monologues, there is a direct, back-and-forth conversation between Bubba and a nameless worker who steps to center stage while strumming a guitar.

"Here you have the American dream. Free housing," Bubba yells. "Did I mention free housing?"

"They put us in a barn, like animals," the worker retorts, strumming some simple chords.

"We have brought you here on air conditioned buses," Bubba again.

"And then for the rest of the summer we get nothing but the air from the back of a tractor in the wicked heat of North Carolina. The closest to a fan may be a chicken flapping its wings."

"Free electricity and running water."

"Just enough dirty water to keep you clean."

"Good working conditions."

"Pesticides by the ton to protect the plants and kill us workers."

"No rent."

"Free barns with one dirty toilet and one broken shower."

"Free medical care and workers' compensation."

"Sure, if you get sick it's a cure to take you back to the border and leave you there." The worker culminates this call and response and introduces himself. "I am Rolando. I will sing you corridos, cumbias, rancheros and romanticas. I will write hymns of justice and freedom for all workers."

Here the subaltern voice calls attention to subordination not through realism but rather through the tactics of exaggeration and sarcasm (Taussig 1999), as when Mexican factory workers in Chicago pantomime the demeanor and dialect of their white supervisors in order to establish some kind of cultural, moral, and emotional relief in the context of a rigid racial hierarchy (De Genova 2005). These "weapons of the weak" that never invert the structural division of labor are meaningful coping mechanisms and instances of political critique for workers with few other resources (Scott 1985). In the play, they are invitations for laughter among interns and workers. The guitarist never disagrees with Bubba. He agrees in a way that is deferent, hyperbolically agreeable, perhaps mimicking the docility that many employers expect from workers and that many workers must embody in order to maintain good standing in the guest worker program. The official discourse about the responsibility of employers and the hospitality of the working environment is made to seem not just untrue, but entirely farcical as well as ideological. Hence, the scene ends with Bubba yelling again. "We can't promise rainbows," he says, "but if you work hard we will pay you all you're worth. Work hard men so that we can pay you. We will pay you for what you pick each hour. So the faster you work the better you will be paid." Juan and some of the other actors turn to the audience and roll their eyes. The audience laughs, and there are lots of nodding heads.

After the play I spoke with several workers in the camp to get their reactions. They thoroughly enjoyed it and told me that the interns seemed very sincere in their interests to become involved in farm labor politics. While the workers told me that the play would not nudge their hesitations about joining the union, they acknowledged that it was evidence that the union was interested in more than just recruitment and numbers. In this way, the internship program is a somewhat less threatening means through which the union can connect with workers because the melodrama of the play communicates what is so entirely hyperbolic about the miseries of migrant labor and the ideologies of the capitalist class without seeming too political. Apart from the negative pressure from growers and labor contractors who spread rumors about outspoken workers being fired, the fear of

unemployment and deportation that pervades immigrant populations is also a key factor that motivates against union membership. The few percentage points in union dues deducted from the wages also seem like a lot to sacrifice for workers who earn agricultural wages and send remittances home. Many unions in Mexico are marred by corruption and workers bring this skepticism to North Carolina. "Besides," a labor organizer tells me in an interview, "many of the workers are not passionate about changing the circumstances or getting involved in our organization. I completely understand. They are tired. They work hard. And they want out of farm labor as soon as possible. I don't blame them for not wanting to join. The changes that we can bring about might not impact them because they might choose to stop migrating year after year. But what we are trying to do is improve things for other workers who will fill their jobs."

It is often assumed that guest worker programs are more humane and preferable to the more dominant system of undocumented labor because they provide protection under the law and legal recourse for workers in seasonal and onerous occupations. But the play (Bletzer 2004) argues that the labor relations in the H2A program involve various forms of constraint that approximate what is found in the informal systems, including indentured servitude and expectations of docility. Guest workers circumvent and resist these constraints, as when they work outside of their contracts, in jobs that they are not legally contracted to accept, often taking advantage of the Mexican and Latino communities in states like North Carolina to access jobs, housing, important cultural places, and social relationships (Fink 2003; Griffith 2007; Murphy et al. 2001). The workers' reactions to the play indicate agreement about the negative attitudes of employers and experiences of dehumanization and demonstrate that they resist the conditions set for them, a factor that has been documented in some of the literature on guest worker programs (Hahamovitch 2000; Griffith 2006).²

That the worker is strumming a guitar is also suggestive of the aesthetic forms that have helped define cultural politics along the border. In the Mexican musical ballad genre the *corrido*, the guitar and vocal performance typically has a Mexican hero standing up to U.S. authorities. A battle between them is its main theme. The typical song in this genre constructs the protagonist not as an individual personality, as with the earlier monologues in the play, but rather as someone whose experience crystallizes a larger, collective figuration of cultural and national community. The heroes, the anthropologist Richard Flores writes of the *corrido*, "are no longer individual personas, but discursive figures who are derived from the social and cultural world of the . . .

authors and audience" (1992:170). The genre's history also contains a pattern of songs that feature dialogues where the migrant heroes respond to demonizing Anglo stereotypes of Mexicans as lazy, deceptive, illegal, and overly fond of alcohol (Limón 1983:217). The songs rely on impersonal narratives and reported speech, exactly what is found in the dialogue with Bubba, to express a common set of injustices that ethnicized laboring populations living in the borderlands endure and contest (Flores 1992). While the play does not take on the exact form of a *corrido*, the reference is there and can be appreciated by the audience of workers; again, this is a mechanism for structuring rapport across the class and cultural divides that separate workers from the thespians, using fun to relay political critique, and encouraging workers to imagine themselves in terms of a common social location and potentially solidaristic behavior with the labor union.

Green Tobacco Sickness

The play's closing scene depicts the crew working in the field when Carlos, the belt maker, becomes ill. Other workers offer him water but realize there are no cups in the field, a violation of labor laws. They instruct him to lie down outside of the vision of the grower since, as one of the workers tells him, he will be "fired if he can't work." Carlos becomes unconscious and the other workers collectively agree to seek medical assistance. Bubba strolls onto the other side of the stage and says in broken Spanish, "Sleeping on the job? Keep working men. He'll wake up in a minute. He's not sick. He's just old and lazy. Get back to work."

In North Carolina, tobacco workers are commonly afflicted with an illness that results from dermal exposure to dissolved nicotine from wet tobacco leaves, called "green tobacco sickness" (Arcury et al. 2003). Prevalence among the state's tobacco workers is about 25 percent. Symptoms include nausea, vomiting, headache, dizziness, weakness, abdominal cramps, breathing problems, and diarrhea (Arcury et al. 2001b). Tobacco sickness is common among foreign-born workers partly because they do the bulk of the manual work; limited work experience in tobacco fields is also a risk factor (Arcury et al. 2001a). Labor advocates and union organizers spend a good deal of time attempting to educate workers about green tobacco sickness. Among farmers, tobacco sickness is culturally framed as an ethnic disease, a "Mexican disease," as farmers sometimes put it (Quandt et al. 1998). Farmers commonly attribute symptoms to drunkenness (e.g., the migrant worker is hung-over from a night of partying in the camp, which might be true) or say that workers who vomit in the field are malingering. These stereotypes, which the play makes evident, may be one reason why efforts to reduce risks (e.g., beginning work later,

after dew has dissipated, or utilizing protective clothing) are uncommon. When the disease is demedicalized, its reality is discredited and cultural beliefs and lack of knowledge become obstacles to efforts that seek to medicalize, treat, and prevent sickness (Arcury et al. 2002a, 2002b; Rao et al. 2004).

As a means of educating workers about this disease and its urgency, the play closes by making the grower's attitude and the wider culture part of this problem. The workers discuss the threat that they might be "blacklisted" for seeking medical attention, not petitioned by Bubba to work in the following year. But one of them with knowledge of the labor union emphasizes the rights of workers to obtain medical help and the important role of the labor union in securing these rights and improving the public health. The worker calls attention to the recently negotiated contract between the labor union and the labor recruitment company, a contract that mandates that Bubba, a contracting employer, provide medical attention.

"This is my farm, here you follow my rules," Bubba retorts. "Not the rules of some union."

"If you don't let us get Carlos some medical help we'll be forced to contact the union and file a grievance," Juan speaks back.

"He's faking it. He just wants a day off. If I let him get away with this, the rest of you will do the same thing tomorrow. Now, if you don't want to be fired, get back to work."

"You can't fire us," Juan says. "How can you stand there and let this man suffer? I'm going to call the union and file a grievance. The contract states that we should have cups in the fields. We should know what pesticides are being used and when it's safe to enter the fields. We should have access to medical care. No matter how much we complain, nothing changes. Don't give up hope. We worked hard for the union contract. I'm going to call Dolores and tell her we would like to file a grievance with the union."

On the other side of the stage, Bubba is now on the phone with Dolores, the union organizer who has been contacted by the workers. "I need some more workers, one of them got sick," Bubba says in his blustery voice. "You got a complaint? You're kidding me. These workers are ridiculous. I didn't do anything to them! What? I'm not going to let these union people bully me. I'll do whatever I want on my farm. What are you saying? This will go to arbitration? They could sue me? Ok, ok, fine! What do they want?"

Strategic Essentialism

In the United States, Mexican migrants are depicted as "other," often regardless of how they present themselves (Chávez 2001; De Genova 2005; Kingsolver 2007). This process is certainly not uni-

form across all social classes, no more than are growers or labor contractors uniformly depicted one way or another. Many efforts are underway in churches, service provider networks, and elsewhere that have developed alternative representations of immigrants, many by immigrant advocates themselves, as reflected in the play. The play's principle political tactic is what Erving Goffman (1959:35) calls "idealization," a mode of performance or theatricality that incorporates and exemplifies values or personality traits that are accredited in the society. Each scene is an entry into a human dimension of migrant life, as well as a refutation of an "out-group view" through the repeated construction of an idealized "in-group view," to use the phrasing of the social theorist Alfred Schutz (1970:85). The play portrays realities that are identifiable to the audience of workers, such as the difficulties of the journey across the border, longing for home and family, verbal abuse from farmers, and risk of agriculture-related health problems. Although the interns insisted that this visit to the camp was not about recruitment, the play concludes with a scene that is clearly about why the union is beneficial to workers. Although the function of the performance was indeed far more recreational than political, that the script is framed to illuminate themes of accountability, ideology, and inequality suggests that it is one way that the interns can make a concrete contribution to organizing efforts. In the hospital room where Carlos is worried that his illness will cause him to lose his job, Dolores speaks to him and the other workers. "You will have cups in the fields tomorrow. All the provisions of the contract will be honored. From now on, and if any of you ever need medical attention again, the grower will act differently. You just call us if you have any more problems. He can't get away with treating you like that. He knows that if he doesn't follow the rules there will be consequences. The workers have the power to make a difference, and he must adjust to the changes that come with a union contract."

The play's other principal tactic is "negative idealization," the overcommunication or exaggeration of stereotypes or aspects of reality for dramatic effect (Goffman 1959:40). The play links the dramatization of migrant life to an overarching contrast with growers that involves lots of generalization and stereotyping and provides a counter-narrative at the same time as it creates something of a straw man: literally, Bubba, chewing on grass and acting all gringo. This is an example of what the theorist Gayatri Spivak calls "strategic essentialism," where images of dominant and subaltern populations are polarized and lent contrasting moral meanings in order to make a stark political point (1996:214). Spivak acknowledges that at least some kind of representation is

required to enact the strategic goals of social movements and political advocacy, which may involve generalization and the sequestering of important details about a particular set of problems. Her critique is not meant to undermine representational politics by pointing out that they are always found to be wanting. Spivak instead emphasizes the necessity of critical reflection about politics and culture in order to complexly understand the effects of a particular representational strategy and appreciate possibilities for unintended consequences.

A scene in the middle of the play is set in Mexico, where Juan is having a conversation with his young daughter before leaving for the work season. "A big giant gringo came and took you away," she frantically tells him of a nightmare. "Why do you need to go to that ugly place?"

"You are old enough to understand that I need to work. You know this."

"Yes, but why do you need to go so far away?"

"There are few jobs here for a poet. Perhaps the giant you saw in the dream was my boss."

"Or the United States," she chuckles and the audience of workers also laughs.

Juan and his daughter exchange gifts before his departure, him giving her a small doll and her giving him a book about famous Mexican revolutionaries. The scene then jumps forward to conclude with a monologue by Juan, who is evidently in a labor camp in North Carolina offering a prayer. "It has rained for days and so all I've earned is enough to pay back for my food and send a little home," he is kneeling, praying. "My beautiful daughter – I spoke to her on the phone. I wish she could understand what it is like to work in this disgusting place. Please help her be so much more than this. I want her to be a doctor or a lawyer. In the tobacco fields they treat us like slaves. They think God loves them more." Once again the script conveys a general theme of a cultural clash while creating a communicative situation around concrete adversities faced by guest workers. Within the H2A program, employers are required to pay workers for a minimum of 35 hours/week only. Workers generally prefer to work more hours to maximize their total earnings during their work tenure. When it rains they are confined to the labor camp, losing hours and wages. Walking away from the contract during periods of idleness is one of the key ways that guest workers resist the conditions they face and it is also one of the main themes about which growers gripe. Given that the H2A program requires that growers pay higher wages, they often complain that guest workers prefer idleness and blame them for wasting business resources, even though idleness is in fact not preferred by workers and is caused by ecological and structural reasons, such as the weather or

a lull in the agricultural season (Griffith 2007). In this context the fear of being blacklisted and the spatial segregation of labor camps are crucial sources of labor discipline for growers, and this is why the play hones in on these themes.

For all of its merits as a commentary on social justice, the script never acknowledges that not all growers treat their workers in a hostile way or that some growers have joined action efforts to help improve labor conditions and advocate for worker rights. The play replicates a simplistic view of immigration as occurring between "sending" and "receiving" countries, a conceptual model that has undergone significant scholarly criticism because it implies that immigration transpires across distinct national cultures and apart from the role of international trade relationships and structures (Kearney 1996). Juan is said to not be able to find a job in Mexico because there is no market for poets there, not because of structural processes that affect him at the same time as they perhaps induce growers like Bubba to treat workers with disrespect. This scene connects an individual home in Mexico to an individual farm in North Carolina, removing migration from the lobbies of Congress, grocery stores where agricultural products are purchased, or boardrooms at multinational corporations.

The politics of solidarity embedded in this one play are not at all representative of what is going on more generally within farm labor organizing, which, in fact, mostly involves strategies to target agribusiness interests and to connect grower and worker interests in innovative ways. Organizers clearly understand and no doubt also educate workers about the role of corporations, as my interviews with FLOC organizers reveal. "Corporate farms are killing small farms" in both countries, says Mark, a FLOC organizer in his mid twenties. Born in the United States, Mark identifies as a Chicano and has family in rural Mexico. He talks about the adverse trends that have come out of free trade agreements and market reforms. "Huge growers who have hundreds of workers abuse the system," he says. "They hire undocumented workers and pay minimum wage. Then there are small growers who don't want to have lawsuits cripple their business and want to go through the law. So they hire guest workers and pay a little more and provide better housing. On many big farms the grower doesn't know what's going on in his camp at all. So he doesn't have a way to correct situations or problems. When the grower is out all day in the fields with a small crew and there is no crew leader, he has better contact."

As part of his job Mark regularly visits camps to keep up with grievances and recruit new union members. He describes a difficult and often thankless task. "On farms with good growers the workers have

not encountered problems and so joining seems irrelevant," he tells me. "In the places where things are bad we run into difficulty because we cannot promise the workers that all their problems will be fixed. The overall problem of exploitation will continue to exist. That is a bigger policy issue." Mark believes that even though growers face serious challenges and constraints in terms of the kind of working conditions they can provide and the high quality of the product that agribusiness companies expect them to deliver, there remains a basic ethical imperative to treat workers with respect and dignity. He contrasts what he calls "good growers" and "bad growers." The good ones are said to respect their workers and understand that the workers are not all the same, replaceable in their location as abstract labor. There is a greater degree of interaction at the workplace, more positive relationships, and better understanding of the needs of workers, like rest and alimentation during the workday, the problems that a lull in the schedule poses for them, and the existential difficulties of migrant life. He tells me about one grower whose crew wanted to take a day off to travel to the Mexican consulate in Raleigh to obtain identification cards to use to purchase alcohol or cigarettes, cash paychecks, and do all of the other things that require identification. The grower worked with the crew to determine a convenient day for such a trip. "Most growers stay separated from the workers and never stop to think about the situation," Mark tells me. "They run their business, that's it. It's easier to be separated. But this particular grower wanted to do a good thing. So he gave workers the day off, but with pay. He drove them into Raleigh. He treated them like people." The bad growers are said to exhibit various kinds of disrespect including being aloof, taking a more austere approach to management, and tending to stigmatize workers as made for manual labor. While Mark acknowledges that this distinction is more of a spectrum he tells me that in his 5 years of experience as a labor organizer in the state he has found that most growers keep distance from workers and without question privilege profit concerns over concerns about labor conditions. Nonetheless Mark tells me that criticism of growers can go too far and that what makes a grower "bad" is usually not his personality but rather the broader structures that define agribusiness.

It is also important to remember that this is a play conceived, written, and performed by students for a summer internship program, and from this perspective it may achieve its goals. These would include not only educating workers concerning their plights and their relations with growers or reaffirming their knowledge of their conditions, perhaps for the purpose of getting them to join the union, but also giving

the students experience interacting with workers and enabling them to learn from their own performance and the audience's reception. In this context, hyperbole, excessive drama, and simplicity of depiction of the conditions facing workers may be appropriate. The use of these and similar methods is not uncommon in farm labor organizing, as I will now discuss.

Conclusions

Farmworkers pose special problems for union organizing due to their legal status, their high rates of turnover, their employment through subcontracts, and the temporary and seasonal dimensions of farm work. Labor unions have developed and refined many strategies to overcome these challenges, including organizing agricultural workers across geographical space and working to revise contractual systems such as the H2A program. In the last two decades, the labor movement in California witnessed increasing union membership rates despite declines across the rest of the country, mainly the result of landmark campaigns that targeted Mexican and Latino workers in low-wage sectors and the systematic engagement of immigrants in various forms of civic and political participation despite their unauthorized status (Gordon 2005; Fine 2006; Milkman 2007).

In a recent article in this journal, the anthropologist David Griffith (2009b) analyzes the successes and failures of strategies of labor organizing that have been employed in the American South. Griffith shows that apart from what is known in labor circles as the "corporate strategy," involving boycott campaigns against major agribusiness and food companies, the use of fine arts and the ability of organizers to convey a sense of solidarity and trustworthiness to workers are the most effective methods (Griffith 2009b:56). Looking specifically at the work of FLOC he shows how that union has been able to effectively establish and maintain a labor organization through the implementation of these strategies. For example, Griffith reports on the use of graphic art among farm labor organizers, which was strategic given the low levels of formal literacy in the farm labor workforce. "In this sense," Griffith writes, "the use of the visual arts is particularly important" (2009b:61). He goes on to describe the use of other media, such as music that FLOC uses in its outreach and educational efforts and public relations with the worker population. There is of course a familiar tradition in anthropology of focusing on the symbolic forms, including theater, that are used by subordinated populations to articulate resistance and conduct labor organizing activities (Nash 1979). My case study confirms that theatrical performance can indeed be an effective means of communicating with and educating workers. The internship program is also an important means of

motivating young people to become involved in social justice struggles and linking the academic world to the real world. At the same time I want to conclude by raising critical questions about the framing of social justice issues in this program and the problematic relationship between labor organizers and the grower population. My concern is that the tobacco-producing region of North Carolina is a social setting where criticism of labor conditions can bring about backlash among growers who have been coached by the tobacco industry to regard outsiders and critics as enemies and who face real financial hardships in their abilities to maintain farm operations. The strategic problems that labor organizers face in this context involve not only the problem of reaching a diverse and dispersed workforce; there is also the challenge of making growers the allies of labor unions.

FLOC organizers comprehend this possibility and have built the union's entire organizing strategy upon recognition of the important fact that growers and workers have a great deal in common. The capacity for making these groups part of the same economic and ethical picture has been a driving force in FLOC's successful boycotts of several major food producers. FLOC targeted Campbell's Soup early in its history. A boycott campaign that began in the late 1970s and lasted 8 years resulted in a labor contract that, according to FLOC's website, changed "the structure of the agricultural system, putting all parties [corporations, growers, farmworkers] on equal footing in negotiating relationships and benefits, under the mediation of a labor relations board representing all parties in the contract" (FLOC 2010). Similar contracts were eventually signed with other large food companies such as Heinz. Rather than simply taking on individual farm operations, FLOC set a precedent in farm labor organizing for its innovative efforts to triangulate disparate interests and to hold accountable the corporations purchasing commodities from growers and wholesalers, and thereby largely dictating farm labor wages and conditions (Griffith 2009b:55).

FLOC's boycott of Mt. Olive Pickle Company, the country's largest independent pickle producer, headquartered in North Carolina, began in 1999 and was endorsed by more than 200 organizations, including the National Council of Churches (Broadway 2003). The union was initially unsuccessful in negotiating with management for improved wages and working conditions. In an editorial in the *Raleigh News and Observer*, the company framed the issue as a localized problem between cucumber growers and workers, claiming negotiations ought to occur on that level. "Since we do not employ farmworkers," a company spokesperson editorialized, "it is inappropriate and unfair for us to interfere." The company sought to deflect attention from its role in competi-

tively sourcing cucumbers and thereby influencing agricultural wages and labor camp conditions (*News and Observer* 1999). FLOC emphasized that a large company like Mt. Olive is "an integral part of the system that contributes to and benefits from the exploitation of these workers" and "Mt. Olive is in a position to influence and improve the conditions of farm workers" (Agricultural Missions Incorporated 2000).

By 2004, the company conceded and the boycott successfully ended. The contract signed by FLOC, the Mt. Olive Pickle Company, and the private North Carolina firm that recruits guest workers for growers resulted in a set of reforms that entail significant benefits for each of these groups, as well as for growers and farmworkers. It resulted in higher wages for farmworkers who work on farms that supply cucumbers to the company. The boycott also led to a company mandate to expand the code of conduct for its suppliers, who must permit ready access to labor camps and workplaces for inspection. Growers benefit from modest annual financial supplements to help them pay for the fees associated with importing legal guest workers and maintaining labor camps. The contract finally led to the establishment of a formal grievance procedure to elide many of the problems that have plagued the H2A program and made guest workers vulnerable in spite of the program's formality. There can be no retaliations on the part of growers against workers who file grievances, no terminations without just cause, and no prohibitions against the right to receive visitors (including labor organizers) in labor camps, and there is the right to compensation for lost time due to injury, medical leaves, and religious leaves (Collins 2004; FLOC 2010). Although all of this seems very threatening to growers, who now face a new level of exposure and oversight, and whose employees are now empowered through the institutional support of the labor union, organizers with whom I spoke regard the grievance procedure as a benefit to growers, too. "This kind of contract system benefits growers in several ways," a FLOC organizer told me in an interview. "Even though growers complain about the union, this boycott won them higher commodity prices and creates a new framework of collective bargaining. Rather than having to face individual lawsuits and the uncertainties that were in place before this contract, where workers felt vulnerable and growers felt protective, there is now a formal process where grievances against particular growers can be negotiated through a fair process that benefits everyone and makes the workplace safer and more productive." FLOC (2010) touts this contract as "a model transnational labor agreement" and finds "ways to benefit all sides in the production of agricultural products."³

It is easy to criticize the play for involving students in a set of tropes that stage labor migration as a cultural clash in an exaggerated manner. This simplified portrayal does not reflect the official position of the union. But the union's boycotts have involved protests at the roadside in front of big farms in order to attract public attention and publicly shame individual growers, whose names appear in the newspapers. FLOC organizers told me in interviews that while they understand that potential backlash can occur, shaming can be tactical in a context in which growers can easily evade legal oversight and union organizing by employing undocumented workers. The Mt. Olive boycott was limited in its capacity to alter material conditions because the union is legally permitted to organize documented workers only, a small fraction of the workforce. Government neglect in permitting employers to hire a more vulnerable undocumented workforce continues to allow buying firms to depress commodity prices and reap the financial benefits of squalid living conditions. FLOC's partnership with the H2A program also means that the union is currently dependent on guest workers as the core of its membership, which creates a structural problem when it comes to its capacity to critique the forms of servitude and company-friendly policies that will inevitably be a part of proposals for new guest worker programs (i.e., "immigration reform") in the future (Griffith 2009b:63).

The play might never be seen by growers. Its audience is the workers and the participating interns. My concern is that the awareness of the complex structural issues that is clearly evident among labor organizers does not fully reach interns whose summer experience is also defined by the practice of blaming and shaming growers. My ethnographic work on this matter is limited. In addition to significant amounts of research with the workforce, I conducted a dozen interviews with labor organizers and spoke informally with the interns after their performance of the play. Further research is needed to understand the culture of labor organizing in North Carolina and the extent to which speaking negatively about growers as bad actors is common and acceptable. Just as anthropologists have shown how tobacco growers respond to structural changes in defensive ways because what is at stake in their businesses and lives seems threatened, it will be important to know more about the moral universe of labor organizing, the extent to which growers are seen as allies or adversaries, and the ways that rural social dynamics shape and are shaped by the political and organizational strategies of these different constituencies.

The cultural politics of good actors and bad actors that orients the moral compass of the play seems crucial to the articulation of solidarity between union

affiliates and workers. But it simultaneously occludes a full appreciation of the role of multinational capital in constraining what growers can do in their relationships to the workforce and the economic motivations and forms of government neglect that help sustain this system of labor subordination. At the local level, the project of remaking farm labor conditions is not simply about making farm labor more visible to consumers or students or bringing about reforms and oversight through contracts with suppliers and agricultural processing corporations. There are also moral and emotional issues that must be considered as part of the overall farm labor strategy, namely the resistance and defensiveness that can be exhibited in the grower population. While representations that vilify growers may have tactical value, my question is whether it is preferential to coach students to participate in this process and to understand adversities of migrant labor in terms of the local accountability of growers. This is precisely how executives at Mt. Olive framed the problem of farmworker plight in their early opposition to the boycott. Growers hire farmworkers, they said, not the company.

The partnership with SAF represents one way in which the labor union seeks to promulgate ideas to the wider community about what is ethical economic behavior, such as paying a living wage and providing safe working environments (Griffith 2009b:60). Because the promotion of this kind of moral economy is a core part of labor organizing activity (Durrenberger 2007) it is important to understand how it might entail the negative idealization of particular actors who are part of the wider community and who are key stakeholders in the local economy. My analysis suggests that other strategies besides blame might permit a more comprehensive approach to political and social reform in a context where the challenges faced by differently positioned groups – growers and workers – are linked. Theatrical performance and public protest are limited in their political reach when they fail to highlight how macro forces of economic restructuring induce antagonisms on the micro level and collude to motivate against collectivization, among both groups. Ultimately, the play's focus on the grower as a mean giant and the workers as heroic giants loses sight of agribusiness corporations as giants that claim absence from local conflicts even though their financial solvency and growth depend on those scenes. In line with my analysis, Mark suggested to me that growers react to external forces as a means of safeguarding their own status and position. "I talk to farmers all the time who see how the global economy hurts their businesses," he tells me. "But it's odd that they do not also see how they are in a similar situation as their workers. When each farmer is just concerned with his contract and not with the

status of other people, then he doesn't look at the system."

Some rural counties in North Carolina have experienced a 10-fold increase in the Latino population in recent years. A combination of agriculture, food processing, landscaping, and construction work draws workers to these regions, where there are vibrant and elaborate Mexican and Latino communities (Griffith 2007). What kinds of community outreach strategies, including the use of fine arts, can be developed by labor organizers and other outreach groups to educate rural populations about the complexities of agribusiness integration and to challenge the stigma and negative attitudes about immigration that are pervasive in many rural regions? Pressures and uncertainties faced by middle-class white citizens such as tobacco growers often contribute to backlash in the form of the menacing treatment of immigrants and the reassertion of supremacy and longstanding racial orders and divisions of labor (Lamont 2002). Clearly the play would differ were the interns coached to sympathize with an individual like Bubba as someone who is also at the mercy of corporate power and who is likely to respond in ways that can be detrimental to others. The internship program would differ were its social justice focus expanded to include issues that face migrants as well as growers and other rural residents. Perhaps rather than framing the internship as a summer experience where students work with laboring populations, the program might involve ethnographic engagement with differently positioned groups and emphasize the value of anthropological research on the subjectivity and moral experience of growers for labor organizing. A climate in which blame is a preferential political tool for anyone undermines capacities for solidaristic behavior and risks feeding into the very social processes that labor organizers seek to remake. The labor union might aim to educate workers about the corporate power and market dynamics that create hardships for growers, and educate growers about the cultural backgrounds of workers and the structural reasons behind labor migration. These approaches would build on an appreciation for the potential for backlash in workplaces defined by historical racial divisions and the cultivated spirit of defensiveness that has rooted loyalties for the tobacco industry.

Anthropologists might contribute to these approaches through research that attends to ethnographic aspects of the lives of tobacco farmers and the rural communities in which they live. In the United States, tobacco scholarship and advocacy have predominantly focused on consumer health issues and increasingly seek to control tobacco through the regulation of consumption. Policymakers and health professionals have historically paid little attention to

tobacco farmers and lacked cultural knowledge about their communities (Altman et al. 1998:381). Anthropological research on tobacco farms is essential for building partnerships in rural communities to counterbalance the political influence of the tobacco industry, promoting collaborative efforts to develop alternative sources of livelihood, and articulating with farm labor struggles. It is important that such research be undertaken with the kind of disposition that builds trust among farmers. Efforts that seek to improve farm labor conditions and make farmers the allies of farmworkers and the public health will be most effective when they do not also imply that farmers are blameworthy for smoking disease or problems linked to labor migration.

Acknowledgments

I would like to offer sincere thanks to those who provided comments on earlier versions of this manuscript, especially Kedron Thomas, two anonymous reviewers, whose insights on farm labor organizing were most helpful, and the editor, Michael Chibnik. Research for this article was funded by a grant from the Wenner-Gren Foundation.

Notes

- 1 For an exemplary social and organizational history of FLOC, and more broadly labor organizing in the American South, see Griffith (2009a, 2009b).
- 2 One of the reasons that agriculture has such a high annual turnover in its workforce is due to workers leaving conditions that structural violence has created. As the anthropologist David Griffith (2007) has noted, North Carolina's Latino population today includes many former guest workers who have settled out of agriculture and now own small businesses or work in other economic sectors.
- 3 It is important to note, as David Griffith (2009b:59) has done, that in the wake of this boycott the private labor recruiting firm that is part of the contract with FLOC has begun to use this relationship as a marketing tool. It publicly tells growers that if they choose to use another firm to recruit H2A workers then they will be far more subject to being sued by North Carolina legal aid and that the contract with FLOC is a guarantee of legal shelter. An unintended consequence of the contract, therefore, is that it may have bolstered this private interest at the expense of competition in the labor recruitment market which could dampen potential social responsibility investments among labor contractors.

References

Agricultural Missions Incorporated. 2000. Report on the Mt. Olive Pickle Boycott by the Farm Labor Organizing Committee and Migrant Farm Worker

Conditions in North Carolina and in the United States. National Council of the Churches of Christ in the USA. Electronic document, <http://www.nccusa.org/publicwitness/mtolive/boycott.html>, accessed June 2008.

Altman, David G., Daniel J. Zaccaro, Douglas W. Levine, David Austin, Carol Woodell, Betty Bailey, Michael Sligh, Gerry Cohn, and James Dunn. 1998. Predictors of Crop Diversification: A Survey of Tobacco Farmers in North Carolina (USA). *Tobacco Control* 7:376–382.

Arcury, Thomas A., and Sara A. Quandt. 2007. Delivery of Health Services to Migrant and Seasonal Farmworkers. *Annual Review of Public Health* 28:345–363.

———, and John S. Preisser. 2001a. Measuring Occupational Illness Incidence and Prevalence in a Difficult to Study Population: Green Tobacco Sickness among Latino Farmworkers in North Carolina. *Journal of Epidemiology and Community Health* 55(11):818–824.

———, John S. Preisser, John T. Bernert, Deborah Norton, and Joanna Wang. 2003. High Levels of Transdermal Nicotine Exposure Produce Green Tobacco Sickness in Latino Farmworkers. *Nicotine and Tobacco Research* 5(3):315–322.

———, John S. Preisser, and Deborah Norton. 2001b. The Incidence of Green Tobacco Sickness among Latino Farmworkers. *Journal of Occupational and Environmental Medicine* 43(7):601–609.

———, and Gregory B. Russell. 2002a. Pesticide Safety among Farmworkers: Perceived Risk and Perceived Control as Factors Reflecting Environmental Justice. *Environmental Justice* 110 (Suppl 2): 233–239.

———, and Samuel Simmons. 2002b. Farmer Health Beliefs About an Occupational Illness That Affects Farmworkers: The Case of Green Tobacco Sickness. *Journal of Agricultural Safety and Health* 9(1):33–45.

Benson, Peter. 2008a. El Campo: Faciality and Structural Violence in Farm Labor Camps. *Cultural Anthropology* 23(4):589–629.

———. 2008b. Good Clean Tobacco: Philip Morris, Biocapitalism, and the Social Course of Stigma in North Carolina. *American Ethnologist* 35(3):1–23.

———. 2010. Tobacco Talk: Reflections on Corporate Power and the Legal Framing of Consumption. *Medical Anthropology Quarterly* 24(4), in press.

Berlant, Lauren. 1997. *The Queen of America Goes to Washington City: Essays on Sex and Citizenship*. Durham: Duke University Press.

Bletzer, Keith V. 2004. Open Towns and Manipulated Indebtedness among Agricultural Workers in the New South. *American Ethnologist* 31(4): 530–551.

Broadway, Bill. 2003. “Churches back boycotts over migrant workers.” *Washington Post*. November 22, p. B9.

Chávez, Leo R. 2001. *Covering Immigration: Popular Images and the Politics of the Nation*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Collins, Kristin. 2004. “Mt. Olive pickle boycott will end with labor pact.” *News and Observer* (Raleigh). September 16, p. 1.

Daniel, Pete. 1972. *The Shadow of Slavery: Peonage in the South, 1901–1969*. Urbana: University of Illinois Press.

———. 2005. *Working the Boundaries: Race, Space, and Illegality in Mexican Chicago*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Delgado-Wise, Raul, and Himberto Marquez Covarrubias. 2006. *The Reshaping of Mexican Labor Exports Under NAFTA: Paradoxes and Challenges*. Zacatecas: Universidad de Zacatecas, Red Internacional de Migración y Desarrollo.

Dudley, Kathryn Marie. 2000. *Debt and Dispossession: Farm Loss in America's Heartland*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Durrenberger, E. Paul. 2007. The Anthropology of Organized Labor in the United States. *Annual Review in Anthropology* 36:73–88.

———, and Suzan Erem. 2005. *Class Acts: An Anthropology of Service Workers and Their Union*. Boulder: Paradigm Publishers.

———, and Kendall M. Thu. 1996. The Industrialization of Swine Production in the United States: An Overview. *Culture and Agriculture* 18(1):19–22.

Early, Julie, Stephen W. Davis, Sara A. Quandt, Pamela Rao, Beverly M. Snively, and Thomas A. Arcury. 2006. Housing Characteristics of Farmworker Families in North Carolina. *Journal of Immigrant and Minority Health* 8(2):173–184.

Edid, Maralyn. 1994. *Farm Labor Organizing: Trends and Prospects*. Ithaca: ILR Press.

- Farmer, Paul. 2004. An Anthropology of Structural Violence. *Current Anthropology* 45(3):303–325.
- Fine, Janice. 2006. *Worker Centers: Organizing Communities at the Edge of the Dream*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press.
- Fink, Leon. 2003. *The Maya of Morgantown: Work and Community in the Nuevo New South*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press.
- FLOC. 2010. Home Page. Electronic document, <http://www.floc.com>, accessed May 2010.
- Flores, Richard R. 1992. The Corrido and the Emergence of Texas-Mexican Social Identity. *The Journal of American Folklore* 105(416):166–182.
- Gentry, Amanda L., Joseph G. Grzywacz, Sara A. Quandt, Stephen W. Davis, and Thomas A. Arcury. 2007. Housing Quality among North Carolina Farmworker Families. *Journal of Agricultural Safety and Health* 13(3):323–337.
- Goffman, Erving. 1959. *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. New York: Anchor Books.
- Gordon, Jennifer. 2005. *Suburban Sweatshops: The Fight for Immigrant Rights*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Griffith, David. 2006. American Guestworkers: Jamaicans and Mexicans in the U.S. Labor Market. University Park: Penn State University Press.
- . 2007. Guestworkers, *Enganchadores*, and Changing Labor Relations in U.S. Rural Communities. *The Journal of Latino-Latin American Studies* 2(4):74–86.
- . 2009a. The Moral Economy of Tobacco. *American Anthropologist* 111(4):432–442.
- . 2009b. Unions without Borders: Organizing and Enlightening Immigrant Farm Workers. *Anthropology of Work Review* 30(2):54–66.
- Griffith, David, and E. Kissam. 1994. *Working Poor: Farmworkers in the United States*. Philadelphia: Temple University Press.
- Hahamovitch, Cindy. 1997. *The Fruits of Their Labor: Atlantic Coast Farmworkers and the Making of Migrant Poverty, 1870–1945*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press.
- . 2000. Creating Perfect Immigrants. Paper presented at the Labor History Conference, Wayne State University, Detroit, MI, October 17.
- Holden, Christopher. 2002. Bitter Harvest: Housing Conditions of Migrant and Seasonal Farmworkers. In *The Human Cost of Food: Farmworkers' Lives, Labor, and Advocacy*. Charles D. Thompson Jr. and Melinda F. Wiggins, eds. Pp. 169–193. Austin: University of Texas Press.
- Hollander, Gail M. 2006. Subject to Control: Shifting Geographies of Race and Labour in U.S. Sugar Agroindustry, 1930–1950. *Cultural Geographies* 13: 266–292.
- Kasarda, John D., and James H. Johnson Jr. 2006. *The Economic Impact of the Hispanic Population of the State of North Carolina*. Chapel Hill: Frank Hawkins Kenan Institute of Private Enterprise.
- Kearney, Michael. 1996. *Reconceptualizing the Peasantry: Anthropology in Global Perspective*. Boulder, CO: Westview Press.
- Kingsolver, Ann E. 2001. *NAFTA Stories: Fears and Hopes in Mexico and the United States*. Boulder: Lynne Rienner.
- . 2007. Farmers and Farmworkers: Two Centuries of Strategic Alterity in Kentucky's Tobacco Fields. *Critique of Anthropology* 27(1):87–102.
- Lamont, Michele. 2002. *The Dignity of Working Men*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Limón, José E. 1983. Folklore, Social Conflict, and the United States-Mexico Border. In *Handbook of America Folklore*. Richard Dorson, ed. Pp. 216–226. Bloomington: Indiana University Press.
- Lipsitz, George. 1995. The Possessive Investment in Whiteness: Racialized Social Democracy and the "White" Problem in American Studies. *American Quarterly* 47(3):369–387.
- Massey, Douglas S., Rafael Alarcón, Jorge Durand, and Humberto González. 1987. *Return to Aztlán: The Social Process of International Migration from Western Mexico*. Berkeley: University of California Press.
- Milkman, Ruth. 2007. Critical Mass: Latino Labor and Politics in California. *NACLA Report on the Americas* 40(3):30–42.
- Murphy, Arthur D., Colleen Blanchard, and Jennifer Hill. 2001. *Latino Workers in the Contemporary South*. Athens: University of Georgia Press.
- Nash, June. 1979. *We Eat the Mines and the Mines Eat Us: Dependency and Exploitation in Bolivian Tin Mines*. New York: Columbia University Press.

- National Institute for Tobacco-Free Kids. 1999. False Friends: The U.S. Cigarette Companies' Betrayal of American Tobacco Farmers. Washington, DC: National Institute for Tobacco-Free Kids.
- News and Observer. 1999. "Organizers pick wrong target, use harsh tactics in Mt. Olive pickle boycott." News and Observer. April 13, p. 10.
- North Carolina Department of Labor. 2008. Introduction to Migrant Housing Inspections in North Carolina. Raleigh: Agricultural Safety and Health Bureau, Division of Occupational Safety and Health. Electronic document, http://www.nclabor.com/ash/ash_blue_book.pdf, accessed July 2008.
- Oxfam America. 2004. Like Machines in the Field: Workers without Rights in American Agriculture. Boston: Oxfam America.
- Portes, Alejandro. 2007. Migration, Development, and Segmented Assimilation: A Conceptual Review of the Evidence. *The Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 610:73-97.
- Quandt, Sara A., Thomas A. Arcury, Colin K. Austin, and Rosa M. Saavedra. 1998. Farmworker and Farmer Perceptions of Farmworker Agricultural Chemical Exposure in North Carolina. *Human Organization* 57(3):359-368.
- Rao, Pamela, Thomas A. Arcury, Sara A. Quandt, and Alicia Doran. 2004. North Carolina Growers' and Extension Agents' Perceptions of Latino Farmworker Pesticide Exposure. *Human Organization* 63(2):151-161.
- Rothenberg, Daniel. 1998. *With These Hands: The Hidden World of Migrant Farmworkers Today*. New York: Harcourt Brace.
- Rouse, Roger. 1991. Mexican Migration and the Social Space of Postmodernism. *Diaspora* 1:8-23.
- Schell, Greg. 2002. Farmworker Exceptionalism Under the Law: How the Legal System Contributes to Farmworker Poverty and Powerlessness. In *The Human Cost of Food: Farmworkers' Lives, Labor, and Advocacy*. Charles D. Thompson Jr. and Melinda F. Wiggins, eds. Pp. 139-166. Austin: University of Texas Press.
- Schutz, Alfred. 1970. The Cognitive Setting of the Life-World. In *On Phenomenology and Social Relations*. Helmut R. Wagner, ed. Pp. 79-124. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Scott, James C. 1985. *Weapons of the Weak: Everyday Forms of Peasant Resistance*. New Haven: Yale University Press.
- Smith-Nonini, Sandy. 1999. *Uprooting Injustice: A Report on Working Conditions for North Carolina Farmworkers and the Farm Labor Organizing Committee's Mt. Olive Initiative*. Durham: Institute for Southern Studies.
- . 2005. Federally Sponsored Mexican Migrants in the Transnational South. In *The American South in a Global World*. J.L. Peacock, H.L. Watson, and C.R. Matthews, eds. Pp. 59-79. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press.
- Spivak, Gayatri. 1996. Subaltern Studies: Deconstructing Historiography. In *The Spivak Reader*. Donna Landry and Gerald MacLean, eds. Pp. 203-236. London: Routledge.
- Student Action with Farmworkers (SAF). 2008. Home Page. Electronic document, <http://saf-unite.org>, accessed July 2008.
- Taussig, Michael T. 1999. *Defacement: Public Secrecy and the Labor of the Negative*. Palo Alto: Stanford University Press.
- Thompson, Charles D. Jr., and Melissa F. Wiggins, eds. 2002. *The Human Cost of Food: Farmworkers' Lives, Labor, and Advocacy*. Austin: University of Texas Press.
- Villarejo, D. 2003. The Health of U.S. Hired Farm Workers. *Annual Review of Public Health* 24:175-193.
- Wilson Daily Times. 1989. "New law should lead to migrant housing improvements." *Wilson Daily Times*, September 4, pp. 1, 8.
- Winters, Donald L. 1998. Agriculture in the Post-World War II South. In *The Rural South Since World War II*. R. Douglas Hurt, ed. Pp. 8-27. Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press.

DOI:10.1111/j.1548-1417.2010.01042.x